

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

COMPARATIVE POLITICS AND SOCIETIES

PIA2050 | WEEK 6: THE POLITICS OF REGIME TRANSITIONS

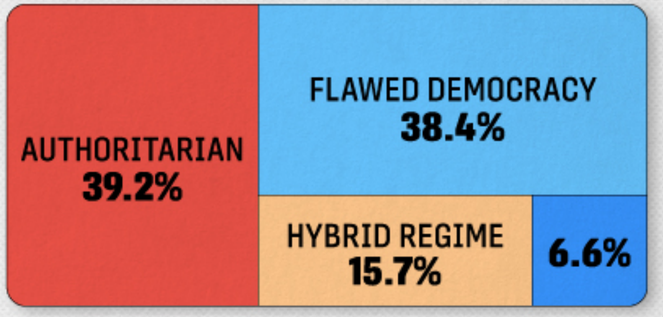
Let’s finish last week’s slides first

Countries are rated on a scale from 0 to 10, with the global average declining slightly to **5.2** in 2024.

GLOBAL DEMOCRACY INDEX SCORE 2024

1 2 3 — AUTHORITARIAN
4 5 — HYBRID REGIME
6 7 — FLAWED DEMOCRACY
8 9 — FULL DEMOCRACY

SHARE OF WORLD POPULATION

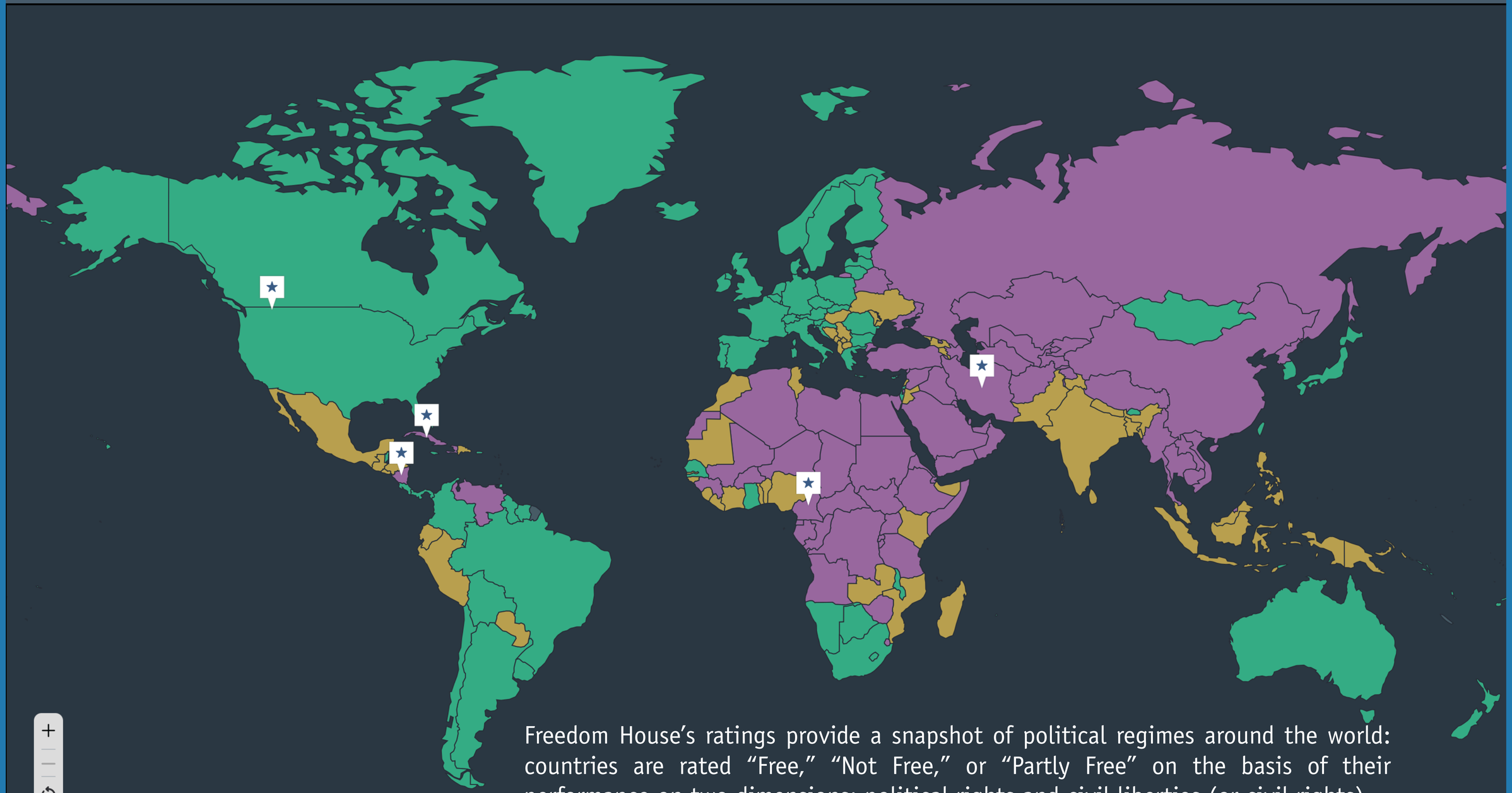


Iceland 9.4
Norway 9.8
Finland 9.3
SWE 9.4
UK 8.3
Denmark 9.3
Ireland 9.2
Poland 7.4
BLR 2.0
GER 8.7
8.1
8.3
6.5
Ukraine 4.9
France 8.0
ROM 6.0
6.3
Georgia 4.7
Portugal 8.1
Spain 8.1
Italy 7.6
Türkiye 4.3
Tunisia 4.7
Greece 8.1
MAR 5.0
Algeria 3.6
Libya 2.3
Canada 8.7
United States 7.9
Russia 2.0
Kazakhstan 3.1
Mongolia 6.5
PRK 1.1
Japan 8.5
7.8 S. Korea
1.7
2.8
Iran 2.0
0.3
2.8
China 2.1
Taiwan 8.8
Egypt 2.8
Saudi Arabia 2.1
Oman 3.1
Yemen 2.0
India 7.3
Cuba 2.6
Haiti 2.7
Mexico 5.3
JAM 6.7
Dominican Rep. 6.6
Guatemala 4.6
Nicaragua 2.1
Venezuela 2.3
Suriname 6.8
Costa Rica 8.3
Colombia 6.4
Ecuador 5.2
MRT 4.0
Mali 2.4
Niger 2.3
Chad 1.9
Sudan 1.5
Senegal 5.9
Nigeria 4.2
4.2
2.6
1.2
ETH 3.2
Liberia 5.6
Ghana 6.2
Gabon 2.2
D.R.C 1.9
5.1
Kenya
5.2
Tanzania
Peru 5.7
Brazil 6.5
Bolivia 4.3
Angola 4.1
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Mauritius 8.2
Madagascar
Namibia 6.5
BWA 7.6
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Lesotho 6.1
South Africa
Chile 7.8
Uruguay 8.7
Argentina 6.5
Myanmar 1.0
6.3
VNM 2.6
Philippines 6.6
Sri Lanka 6.2
Malaysia 7.1
Indonesia 6.4
Papua New Guinea 6.0
Fiji 5.4
Australia 8.9
New Zealand 9.6

Freedom in the World: Freedom in the World is the most widely read report of its kind, tracking political rights and civil liberties worldwide.

Filter by Freedom Score: NOT FREE | PARTLY FREE | FREE

FREEDOM IN THE WORLD 2026



Freedom House's ratings provide a snapshot of political regimes around the world: countries are rated "Free," "Not Free," or "Partly Free" on the basis of their performance on two dimensions: political rights and civil liberties (or civil rights).

Freedom in the World 2024 Methodology Questions

SCORING PROCESS

Freedom in the World uses a two-tiered system consisting of scores and status. The complete list of the questions used in the scoring process, and the tables for converting scores to status, appear at the end of this essay.

Scores – A country or territory is awarded 0 to 4 points for each of 10 political rights indicators and 15 civil liberties indicators, which take the form of questions; a score of 0 represents the smallest degree of freedom and 4 the greatest degree of freedom. The political rights questions are grouped into three subcategories: Electoral Process (3 questions), Political Pluralism and Participation (4), and Functioning of Government (3). The civil liberties questions are grouped into four subcategories: Freedom of Expression and Belief (4 questions), Associational and Organizational Rights (3), Rule of Law (4), and Personal Autonomy and Individual Rights (4). The political rights section also contains an additional discretionary question addressing forced demographic change. For the discretionary question, a score of 1 to 4 may be subtracted, as applicable (the worse the situation, the more points may be subtracted).

The highest overall score that can be awarded for political rights is 40 (or a score of 4 for each of the 10 questions). The highest overall score that can be awarded for civil liberties is 60 (or a score of 4 for each of the 15 questions). The scores from the previous edition are used as a benchmark for the current year under review. A score is typically changed only if there has been a real-world development during the year that warrants a decline or improvement (e.g., a crackdown on the media, the country's first free and fair elections), though gradual changes in conditions—in the absence of a signal event—are occasionally registered in the scores.

Free, Partly Free, Not Free Status – The combination of the overall score awarded for political rights and the overall score awarded for civil liberties, after being equally weighted, determines the status of Free, Partly Free, or Not Free (see table below).

NON-DEMOCRACY

Note that different countries are "Not Free" in different ways or for different reasons. Some are ruled by personalized dictatorships, some by kings (monarchies), some by military generals, some by one-party regimes, and some by theocratic governments.

Note that many/most of these countries have laws or constitutions that purport to guarantee civil and political rights on paper.

Again, many classifications/typologies have been proposed over the years. One of the most widely used typologies of dictatorial regimes was formulated by Linz and Stepan (1996), who distinguished between:

* Authoritarian regimes;
* Totalitarian regimes;
* Post-totalitarian regimes;
* Sultanistic regimes.

SEMI-OPEN AUTOCRACIES (N = 48)				
Albania	Fiji	Ivory Coast	Mozambique	Singapore
Algeria	Gabon	Jordan	Niger	Tanzania
Angola	Georgia	Kenya	Pakistan	Thailand
Bangladesh	Guatemala	Kuwait	Papua New Guinea	Togo
Benin	Guinea-Bissau	Kyrgyzstan	Philippines	Tonga
Bosnia-Herzegovina	Haiti	Madagascar	Russia	Tunisia
Central African Republic	Honduras	Malaysia	Senegal	Turkey
Comoros	Hungary	Mauritania	Serbia	Uganda
Congo, DR	Iran	Monaco	Sierra Leone	Zimbabwe
El Salvador	Iraq	Morocco		
CLOSED AUTOCRACIES (N = 41)				
Afghanistan	China	Ethiopia	Nicaragua	Syria
Azerbaijan	Congo, R	Guinea	Oman	Tajikistan
Bahrain	Cuba	Kazakhstan	Qatar	Turkmenistan
Belarus	Djibouti	Korea, North	Rwanda	United Arab Emirates
Brunei	Egypt	Laos	Saudi Arabia	Uzbekistan
Burundi	Equatorial Guinea	Libya	Somalia	Venezuela
Cambodia	Eritrea	Mali	South Sudan	Vietnam
Cameroon	Eswatini	Myanmar	Sudan	Yemen
Chad				

TOTALITARIANISM

Under Totalitarianism, state seeks to regulate every aspect of its citizens' public/private life (incl. through extensive surveillance/terror):

* Giovanni Gentile wrote that in these regimes, the state provides "total representation of the nation and total guidance of national goals."
* Benito Mussolini described his regime as: "Everything within the state, nothing outside the state, nothing against the state."

Totalitarian regimes exercise a complete monopoly on political power. Also, they encourage/force mass participation in the activities of the state and inculcate in the people an "all-encompassing" or "total" ideology legitimizing/guiding the regime.

Historically, totalitarian regimes have been either communist (USSR under Stalin, China under Mao, North Korea under Kim Il Sung) or nazi-fascist (Italy under Mussolini; Germany under Hitler).

POST-TOTALITARIANISM

Note that the historical examples of totalitarianism are very few and have not existed for decades. For most of their histories, the USSR's and the PRC's communist regimes, as well as Italy's fascist regime, were instances of "incomplete totalitarianism."

More recently, the PRC, while still nominally governed by a communist regime, transitioned to "post-totalitarianism" after the party de-emphasized its reliance on ideology, abandoned the active mobilization of the population, and relaxed its control of the economy.

Why have totalitarian regimes declined? Two reasons above all:

(i) It is hard to exercise "total" control of a large territory and a population of millions. The onset of modernity also poses a problem, insofar as it makes it hard to keep out inconvenient information.

(ii) "Total ideologies" were comprehensively defeated in WW2 and the "Cold War".

AUTHORITARIANISM

Under "Authoritarianism," conversely, the state does not have quite the same role:

* Power is somewhat more constrained as well as more dispersed, possibly to the point that some limited pluralism in the political or the socio-economic sphere is allowed.
* Guiding ideologies are less important and are interpreted more flexibly; the regime bases its legitimacy on tradition/culture, national security/interest, or economic performance.
* Less/no emphasis is placed on active participation; passive obedience is what the state wants and demands from the population.

The textbook distinguishes between "traditional authoritarianism," "military authoritarianism" (ak.a., "bureaucratic-military authoritarianism"), "religious authoritarianism," and "electoral authoritarianism."

SULTANISM

Finally, under "Sultanism," power is centered around an individual leader and his family, who amass extensive wealth by plundering state coffers.

The regime is characterized by the absence of any constraints on power, endless glorification/cult of personality of the leader, the prohibition of all oppositions, fear/surveillance, endemic corruption, hereditary succession, and typically the lack of any legitimacy. State officials derive their positions and their power from their personal relationship with the leader and his family.

Historically, "Sultanism" evolved from communist regimes (North Korea under Kim Il Sung, Romania under Ceaucescu), from party-based or military-based authoritarian regimes (examples of the former are Iraq under Saddam Hussein, Syria under the Assads; examples of the latter are Libya under Ghaddafi, Indonesia under Suharto), and even from electoral democracies (e.g., the Philippines under Marcos).

TABLE 9.1 Subtypes of Autocratic Regimes

	Traditional Authoritarianism	Military Authoritarianism	Theocratic Authoritarianism	Electoral Authoritarianism	Pre-Totalitarianism; Incomplete Totalitarianism	Full Totalitarianism	Post-Totalitarianism	Sultanism
POLITICAL PARTIES AND ELECTIONS AND OVERALL POLITICAL OPPOSITION	Can range from all parties being forbidden and no elections held to a multi-party system with competitive elections and limited political opposition (but without elections actually determining the government).	Usually all parties are forbidden, but there could be one official party; limited political opposition may be tolerated.	Either one official party or all parties are forbidden, although anti-regime independents may be elected.	More than one political party; limited political pluralism and consequent political opposition; however, national elections are not free and fair enough to actually change the government.	One official party with a monopoly of power and no political pluralism.	One official party with a monopoly of power and no political pluralism; political terror is often used initially to eliminate any possibility of organized opposition.	Still one official party with monopoly of power but beginnings of political pluralism.	There may be an official party, but it is not well institutionalized; political terror is often used to eliminate any possibility of organized opposition.
SOCIO-ECONOMIC PLURALISM	Can range from no significant to quite extensive social pluralism; usually economic pluralism.	Some social and economic pluralism, perhaps predating the military regime.	No significant social pluralism; usually some economic pluralism.	Many autonomous actors in economy and broader society.	Some social and economic pluralism, perhaps predating the regime.	No significant social or economic pluralism; basically total regime control; strong hostility to pre-existing organized religion.	Limited social and economic pluralism, involving dissidents and some market actors and forces.	Some economic and social pluralism, but these are subject to arbitrary despotic intervention.
CIVIL LIBERTIES	Civil liberties can range from none at all to merely incomplete.	Civil liberties are non-existent or at best limited.	Civil liberties are non-existent or at best limited.	Civil liberties are usually incomplete if not indeed limited.	Civil liberties are non-existent or, at best, limited.	No civil liberties.	Tentative but limited civil liberties.	No civil liberties.
IDEOLOGY	Stress on deference to traditional authority.	Often very nationalistic; stress on economic and, occasionally, social development.	Ideology derived from specific religious text or school.	Stress on economic growth and social peace.	Elaborate and guiding ideology that includes a desired utopian vision.	Elaborate and guiding ideology that includes a desired utopian vision.	Still a state-sanctioned, elaborate, and guiding ideology but weakened faith in this.	No ideology worth its name; instead, personal glorification of leader and family.
MOBILIZATION	Participation largely generated autonomously by civil society (where permitted).	Emphasis on demobilization, especially of pre-existing autonomous civil society.	Emphasis on religious mobilization.	Participation largely generated autonomously by civil society and by competing parties.	Beginning of or partial mobilization into a wide range of regime-created obligatory organizations.	Extensive mobilization into a wide range of regime-created obligatory organizations; active participation and enthusiasm both encouraged and expected.	Still extensive mobilization into regime-sponsored organizations, but enthusiasm replaced by boredom or careerism; dissidents organize clandestinely.	Only occasional mobilization, such as of violent para-state groups.
LEGITIMACY OF AUTHORITY	Traditional legitimacy.	Legitimacy comes from claims of acting in the national interest.	Legitimacy comes from religious position and the authority to interpret relevant scripture.	Legitimacy comes from the illusion of legal-rational authority.	Legitimacy comes initially more from the method of coming to power (e.g., elections or independence struggle) than from the official ideology.	Legitimacy comes from some combination of official ideology (especially its utopian goals) and the charisma of the dictator.	Legitimacy weakened by de-ideologization; shift to attempts at performance legitimacy.	Regime lacks broad legitimacy; compliance is based largely on fear, rewards, and personal ties to leader.
CONSTRAINTS ON AUTHORITY	Constrained at most only somewhat by the bureaucracy, private economic actors, and general public opinion.	Constrained at most only somewhat by the bureaucracy and private economic actors and maybe by any private media.	Constrained at most only somewhat by any private economic actors or private media.	Constrained only somewhat by the constitution, the courts and the rule of law, the bureaucracy, and socio-political pluralism.	Constrained somewhat by any remaining separate political actors and broadly supported private actors.	Key totalitarian leader rules with undefined limits and great unpredictability; successors tend to be more predictable and bureaucratic.	Top leaders constrained by party bureaucracy and state technocrats, but not by broader civil society.	Highly personalistic and arbitrary rule that is highly unpredictable; no bureaucratic professionalism possible.
POLITICAL ACCOUNTABILITY TO POPULATION	No political accountability of the monarch, but there may be some accountability of officials.	No political accountability.	No political accountability.	No true political accountability, although regime does prefer to be popular in actuality.	No political accountability.	No political accountability.	No political accountability, except to other party elites.	No political accountability.
LEADERSHIP DURATION	Leadership is for life and then carries on within the royal family.	Leadership is indefinite unless the military rotates power.	Leadership at the top is for life; a religious assembly chooses successors.	Leadership is indefinite unless the ruling party has internal limits (which have been as little as one term).	For arrested totalitarianism, leadership is indefinite but effectively conditional on avoiding major policy failure.	Leadership effectively for life unless regime is defeated; usually a power struggle for new leader.	Leadership effectively for life; subject to performance; successor picked peacefully by and from party oligarchy.	Leadership effectively for life unless overthrown.
TRANSITION TO (LIBERAL) DEMOCRACY	The monarch and the royal family must be willing to settle for a largely figurehead role.	Transition does not usually occur until either the military loses legitimacy (for example, by losing a war) or thinks that it has sufficiently restructured the socio-political order.	Transition has never occurred willingly.	The key step is having a truly free and fair election; then it becomes improving civil liberties and government fairness.	For arrested totalitarianism, the ruling party must first accept giving up or be forced to give up its monopoly of power.	Needs to go first through a post-totalitarian phase with some pluralism unless defeat in war and occupation by foreign power willing to democratize.	Depending on the maturity of the post-totalitarianism regime, scenarios can range from regime collapse followed by an interim government to a negotiated transition.	Sultan highly unlikely to abdicate so must be overthrown; however, actors close to sultan may fill the resulting power vacuum and frustrate true democratization.

SOURCE: Based in part on Juan J. Linz and Alfred Stepan, *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation: Southern Europe, South America, and Post-Communist Europe* (Baltimore, MD: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1996), Table 3.1 and Table 4.2, with modifications.

TODAY'S PLAN

We dedicated last week's class to the *descriptive* task of surveying the most common regime types are around the world.

This week is dedicated to the *explanatory* task of investigating processes of "democratization" (processes by which a regime becomes *more* democratic) and "de-democratization" (processes by which a regime becomes *less* democratic).

We start with non-democratic regimes and we examine some of the main reasons why such regimes may become unstable to the point of making it possible for democratization to take place. We continue with democratic regimes and we discuss the following questions:

(i) What accounts for the spread of democracy in the past 200 years;
(ii) What makes democratic regimes more or less "stable;"
(iii) What accounts for the regional variation in regime types.

PART I: AUTOCRACIES

AUTOCRATIC RULE

Last week we covered a variety of non-democratic, dictatorial regimes. An important book by Svolik (2012) criticized that typology and offered some additional criteria to understand the variation in the politics of autocratic/authoritarian rule:

(1) Military Involvement;

(2) Restrictions on Political Parties;

(3) Legislative Selection;

(4) Executive Selection.

TABLE 2.2. *Restrictions on Political Parties and Military Involvement in Authoritarian Politics, 1946–2008*

Military Involvement in Politics	Restrictions on Political Parties
None	Parties banned
Indirect	Single party
Personal	Multiple parties
Corporate	

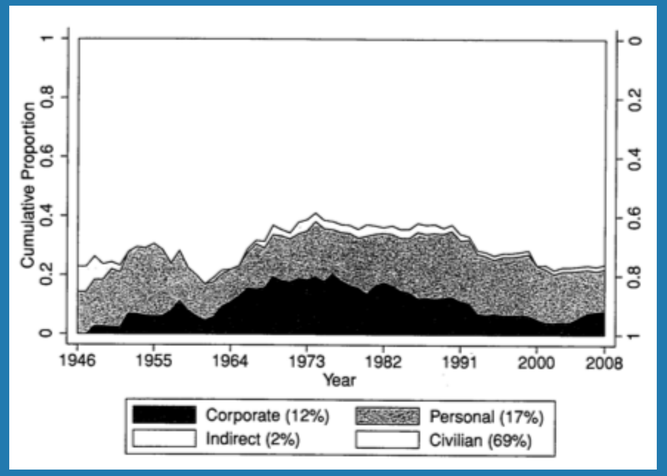
Note: See the codebook for details about coding rules for each category.

TABLE 2.3. *Legislative and Executive Selection in Dictatorships, 1946–2008*

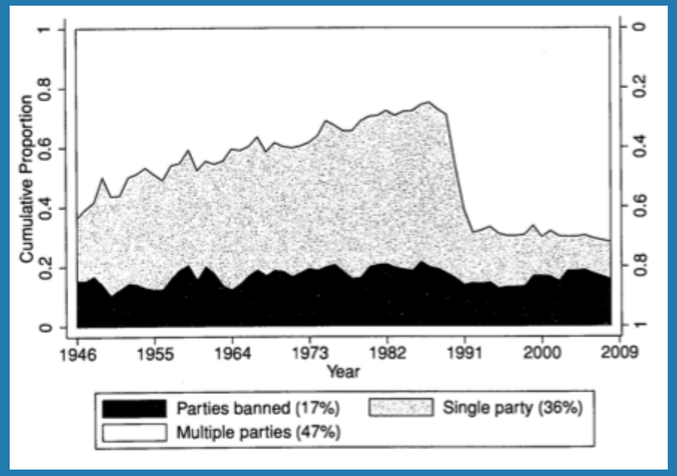
Concentration of Power	
Legislative	**Executive**
None	Unelected
Unelected or appointed legislature	One party or candidate
One party or candidate per seat	Selected by a small, unelected body
Largest party controls more than 75% of seats	Elected by more than 75% of the vote
Largest party controls less than 75% of seats	Elected by less than 75% of the vote
Nonpartisan legislature	

Note: See the codebook for details about coding rules for each category.

Military Involvement



Restrictions on Political Parties



Legislative Selection

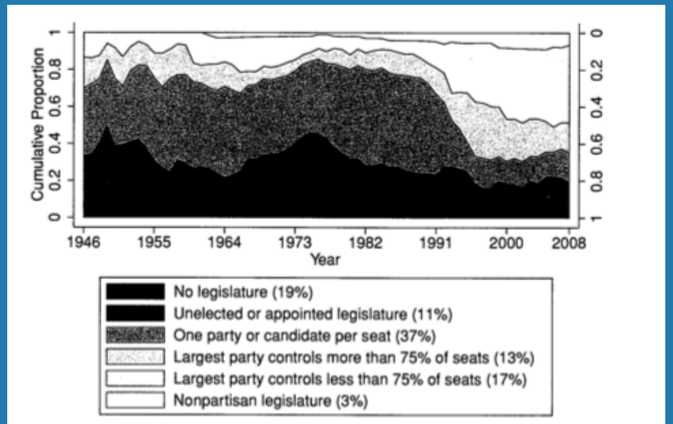


FIGURE 2.6. Legislative selection in dictatorships, 1946–2008. *Note:* Overall distribution of individual categories in parentheses.

Executive Selection

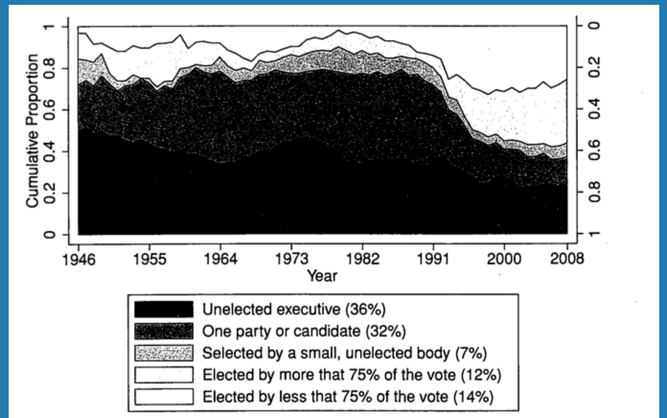


FIGURE 2.7. Executive selection in dictatorships, 1946–2008. *Note:* Overall distribution of individual categories in parentheses.

Source: Svolik, Milan. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press.

AUTOCRATIC RULE

Svolik (2012) describes authoritarian politics in terms of two conflicts:

* Between ruler/ruled: dictators must deal with the majority of the population, which is excluded from power (the problem of authoritarian control);
* Between dictator and those with whom he/she shares power (the problem of authoritarian power-sharing): power sharing is required for dictators to govern, usually through alliances with traditional elites, party members, or generals, who in turn can present challenges to the autocrat's rule (in fact, that is how most dictators fall).

How dictators resolve the problems depends on how they adjust to the defining features of authoritarian politics: (i) The lack of independent authority that can enforce agreements between political actors (esp. dictator and allies); and (ii) The ever present character of violence as ultimate arbiter of conflicts.

AUTOCRATIC RULE

1. The problem of authoritarian power-sharing

Ruling dictatorially requires the assemblage of a "ruling coalition" sufficiently strong to guarantee the regime's survival.

Coalition failures often result from the autocrat's desire/opportunity to get more power at the expense of allies, the only deterrent of which is the allies' threat to remove him. The worst coalition failure is the emergence of a "personal autocracy."

More generally, the interaction between dictator/coalition can take two forms:

(i) Contested autocracy: politics consists of balancing between dictator/allies, who are effective in checking the dictator by presenting a credible threat of rebellion;

(ii) Established autocracy: Monopoly on power by dictators (who generally lose power via death, invasion, revolution).

AUTOCRATIC RULE

Successful solutions of the problem generally entail the adoption of political institutions that reduce the secrecy within elites—these are generally decision-making bodies embedded in ruling parties or legislatures.

These institutions establish formal rules of membership, advancement, decision-making in the regime that facilitate exchange of info and provide easy assessment of compliance: interaction between dictator/supporters is transparent and regularized. Also prevent miscommunications and reassure allies that the dictator is committed to power-sharing.

However, these arrangements only work if allies have at their disposal a credible threat to use force against any dictator who usurps their power/ prerogatives.

AUTOCRATIC RULE

2. The problem of authoritarian control

The problem is addressed by repression and co-optation, both of which have pros as well as cons:

(i) Co-optation often involves the establishment of political parties, which are typically designed to maintain a loyal, popular base of support by hierarchical assignment of services/benefits, by controlling appointments, and by selective recruitment/repression. Parties not only distribute rewards in exchange for loyalties, but exploit career aspirations in the population and give the most capable/opportunistic citizens a stake in the perpetuation of the regime, encouraging investments in its preservation.

Other, less sophisticated ways of "purchasing" the loyalty of the population by diverting resources better spent elsewhere have often proven unsustainable in the long-run (more of this in Week 12).

AUTOCRATIC RULE

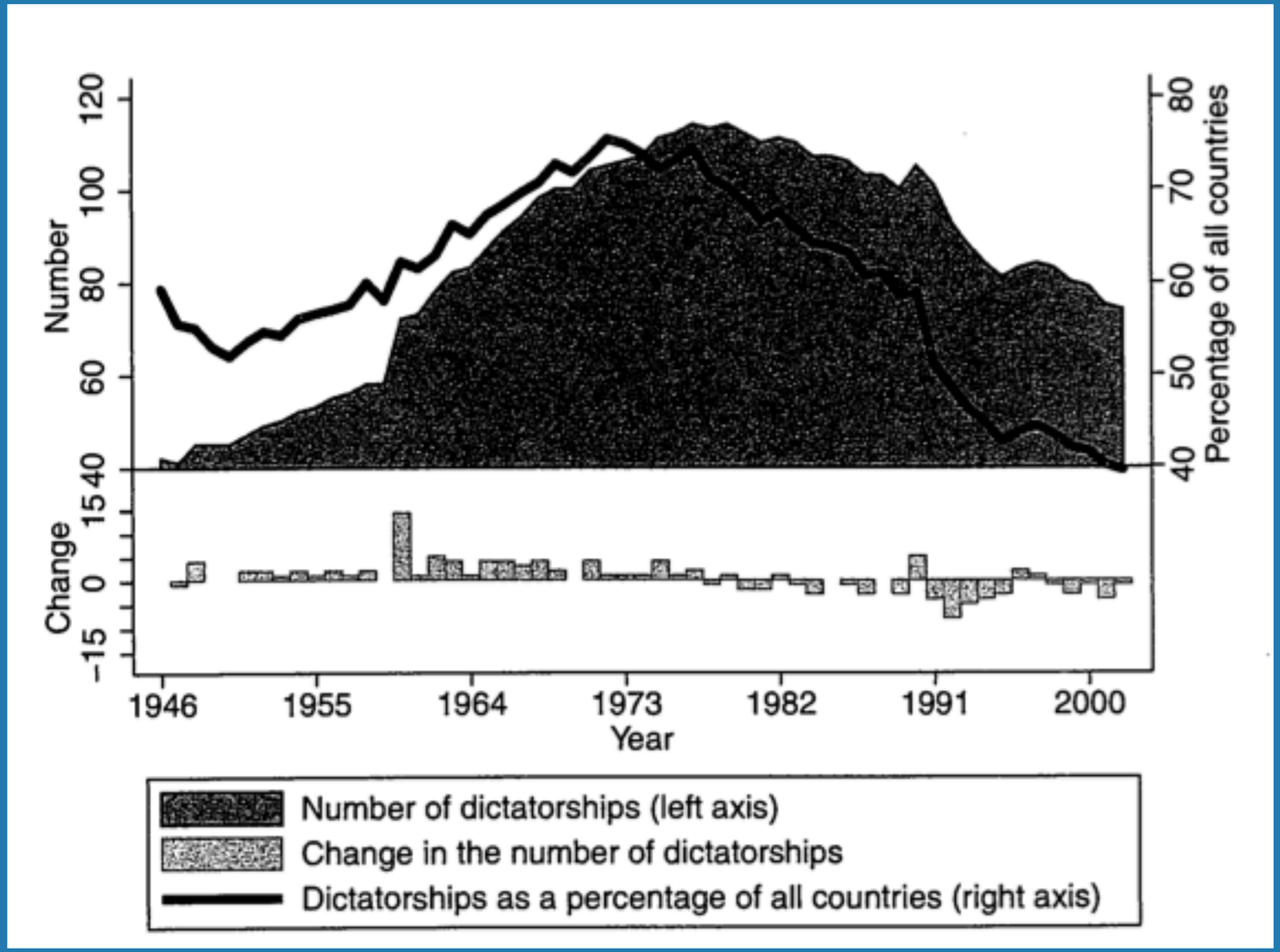
(ii) Likewise, while the benefits of repression are obvious, it is equally well-known that repression is something of a double-edged sword.

Aside from potentially antagonizing the population, repression creates a moral hazard: by empowering repressive agents, the regime also increases their capacity to challenge the dictator, and to acquire leverage they can exploit to extract concessions well beyond what is required to get them to help suppress potential oppositions.

The dictator and his allies can work to diminish the power of the military, but if the regime is confronted with challenges from below, the military is needed to defend from such threats.

Generally speaking, military influence is heightened by concentration of wealth in the hands of a privileged minority, government control over natural resources, and the exclusion of minorities on ethnic/sectarian grounds.

PART II: DEMOCRACIES



Source: Svolik, Milan. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press.

DEMOCRATIZATION

The literature generally divides the process of "democratization" in two phases:

1. DEMOCRATIC TRANSITION:
The process by which a non-democratic regime becomes democratic.

2. DEMOCRATIC CONSOLIDATION:
The process by which a democratic regime achieves some permanence and stability.

A democracy is generally said to be "consolidated" if/when it becomes, in the words of Linz & Stepan (1996), "the only game in town."

What does that mean? It means that all major political forces are committed to pursuing their interests and agendas through the democratic process; that is, they cannot even envision a scenario in which they would support the establishment of a different regime, or use force to seize power.

DEMOCRATIZATION

Samuel Huntington's 1991 book *The Third Wave* proposes that the world's democratization has taken place in three "waves:"

* 1st WAVE (1828-1926): Rise of Western democracies.
* 2nd WAVE (1942-1962): End of WWII and decolonization.
* 3rd WAVE (1973-1991, possibly until 1999): Different factors.

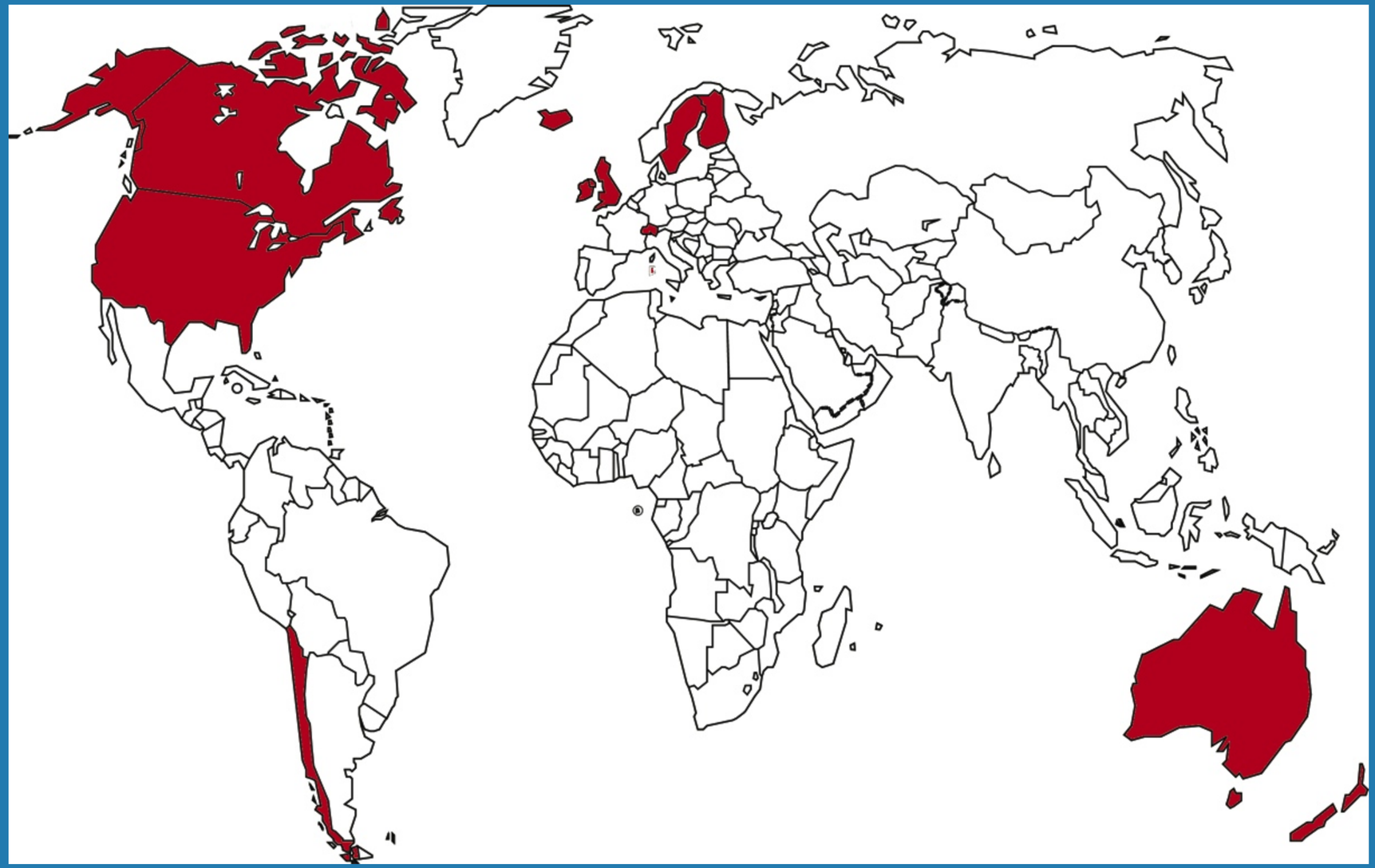
Each of the first two "waves" was followed by a "reverse wave:"

* 1st REVERSE WAVE (1922-1942): Esp., the rise of Fascism.
* 2nd REVERSE WAVE (1958-1973): Dictatorships take over countries in Asia, Africa, and Latin America.
* 3rd REVERSE WAVE? Since the year 2000, the number of electoral democracies and full democracies either stagnated or declined.

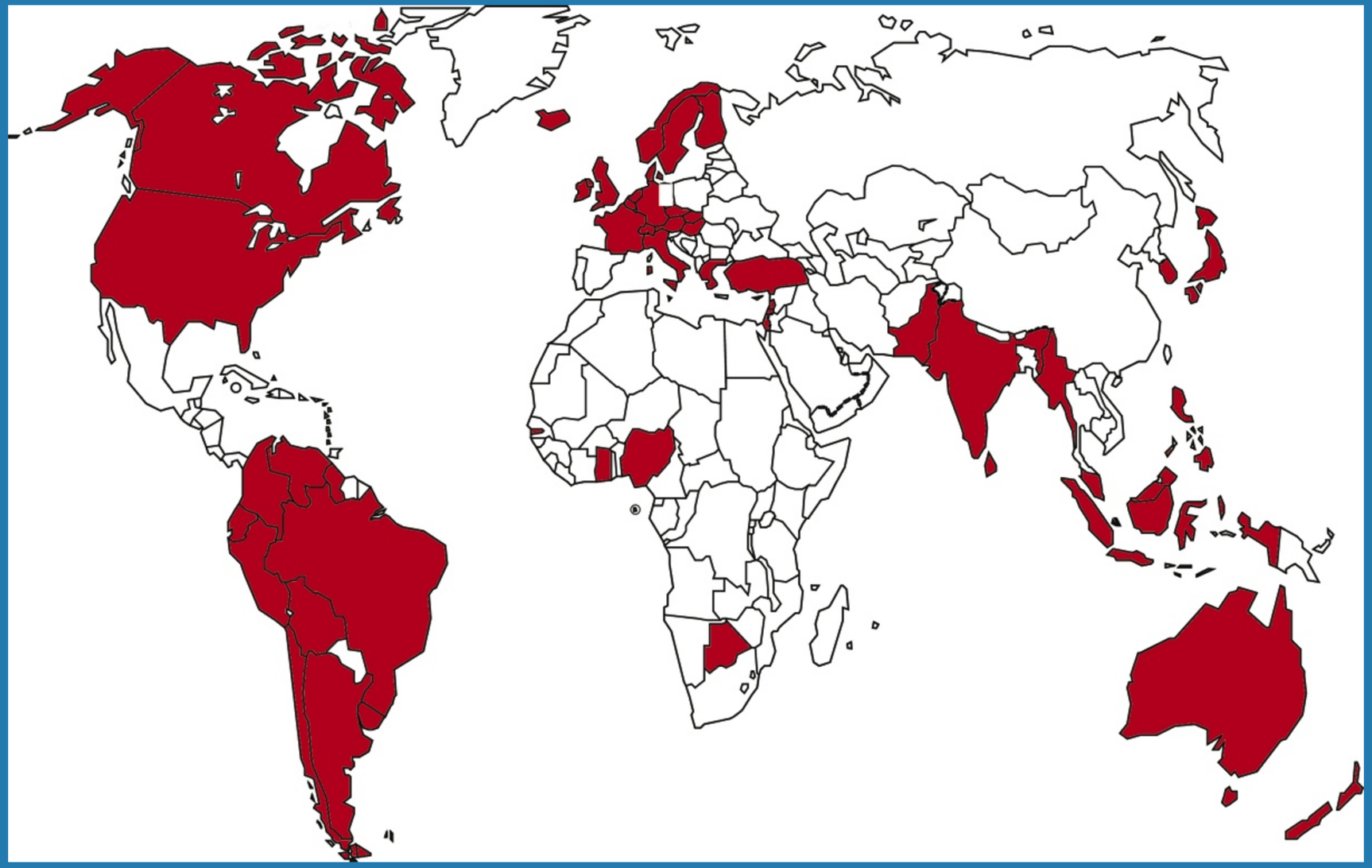
‘1ST WAVE’ (1828-1920)



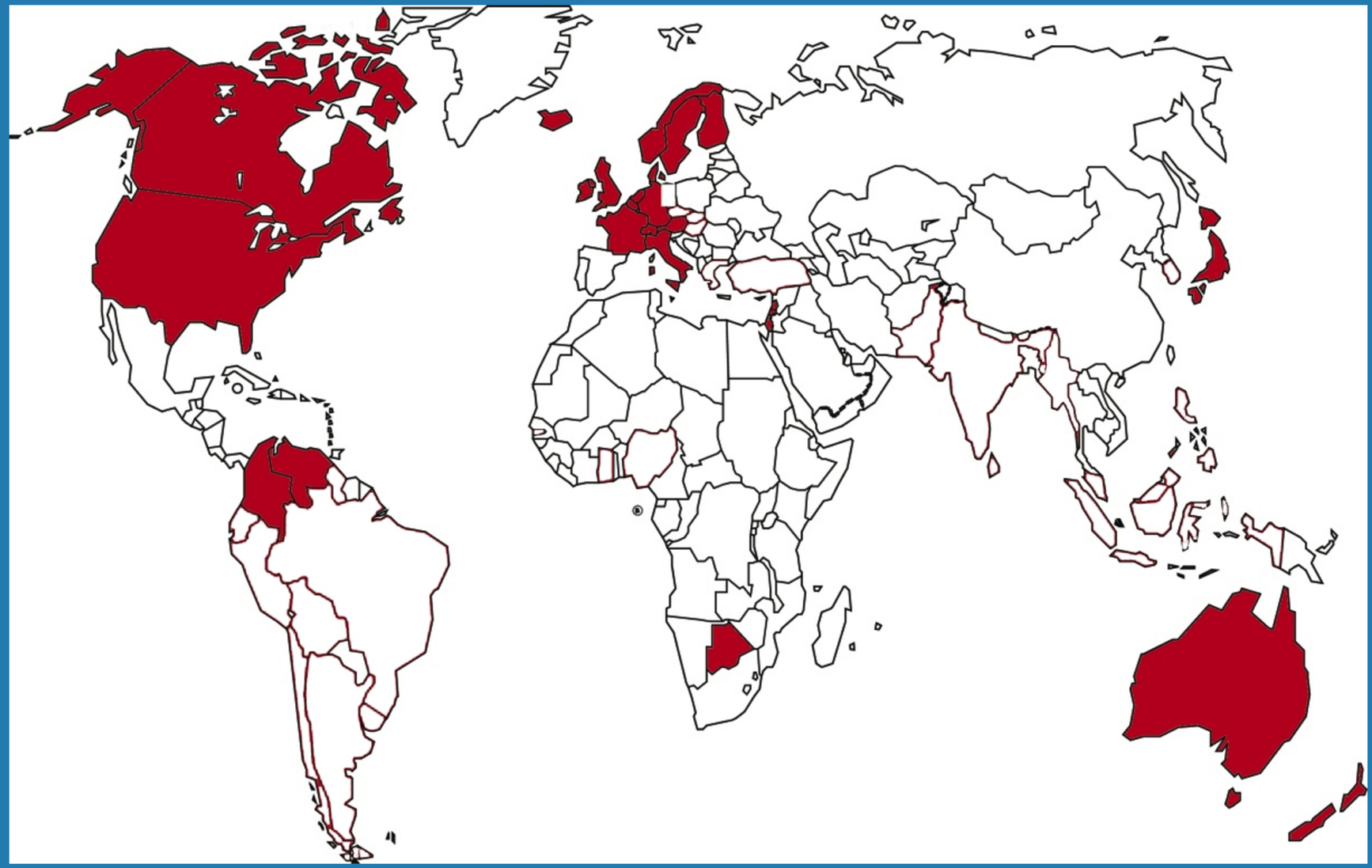
‘1ST REVERSE WAVE’ (1922-1942)



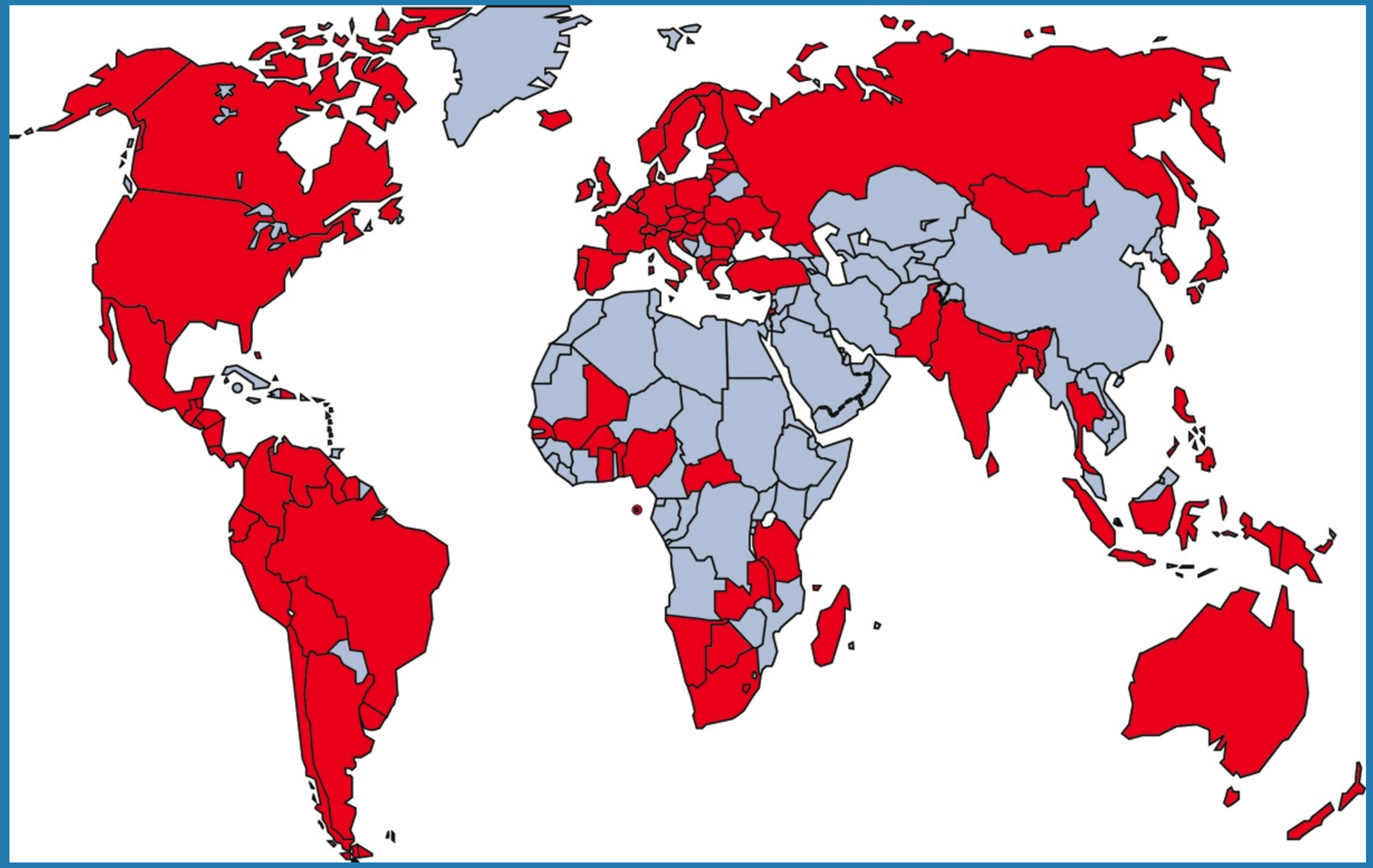
‘2ND WAVE’ (1942-1962)



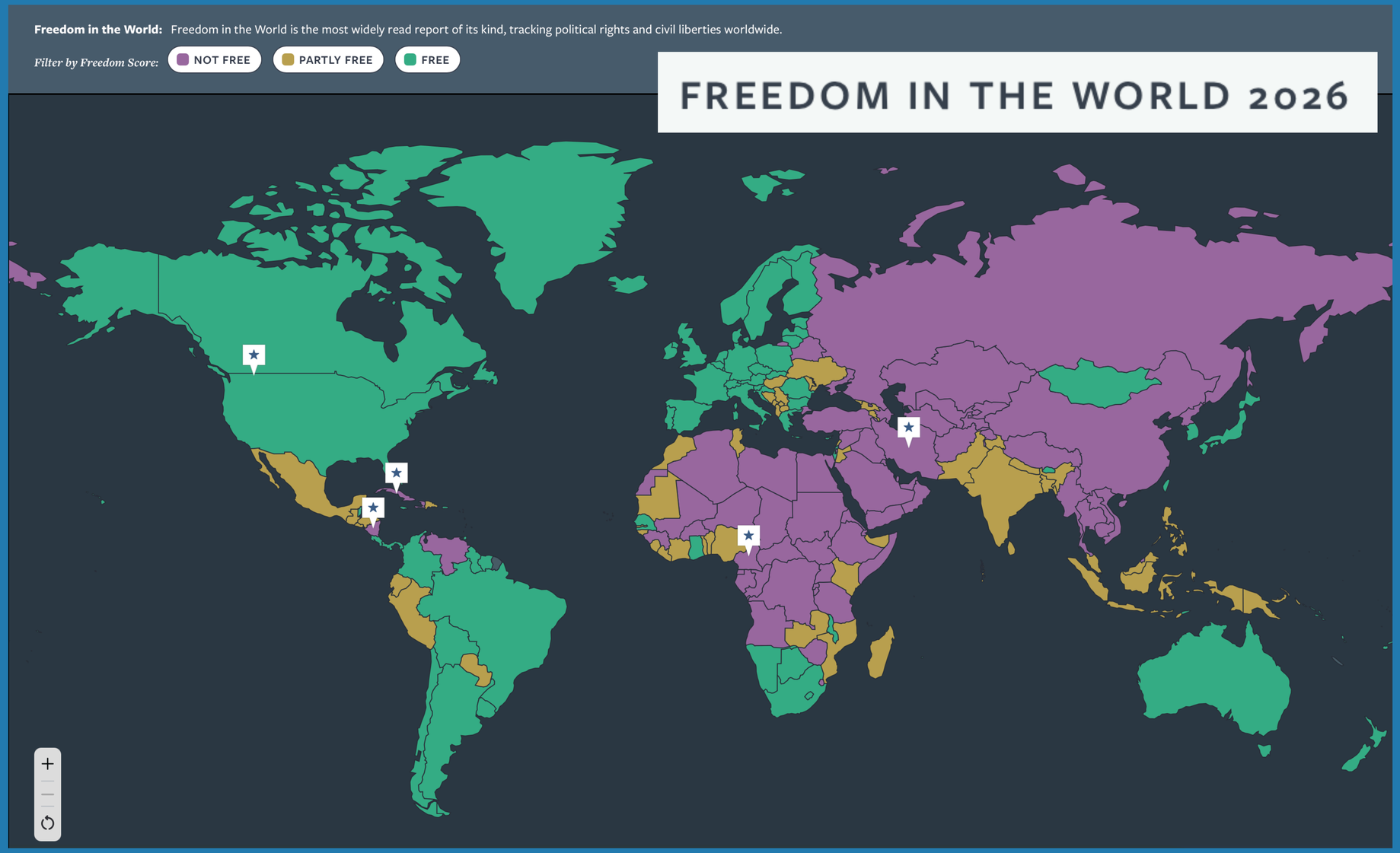
‘2ND REVERSE WAVE’ (1958-1973)



‘3RD WAVE’ (1973-1999)



‘3RD REVERSE WAVE?’ (2000-?)



DEMOCRATIZATION

Huntington (1991) identified three types of transitions:

* TRANSFORMATIONS: Transitions initiated and guided by the authoritarian regime previously in power;
* REPLACEMENTS: Transitions resulting from the actions of an opposition, which causes the collapse/overthrow of an autocracy.
* TRANSPLACEMENTS: Transitions take place by means of a series of deals/ compromises between the previous regime and democratic forces.

Huntington (1991) also pointed out that different countries are likely to undertake different "paths" to democratization, depending in part on the nature of the autocratic regime that is being dislodged from power.

TABLE 10.3 Processes of Transition to Democracy

	NON-DEMOCRATIC REGIME TYPE						
PROCESS	**Racial Oligarchy**	**Electoral Authoritarian**	**Military Authoritarian**	**Theocratic Authoritarian**	**Incomplete Totalitarian or Post-Totalitarian**	**Full Totalitarian**	**Sultanistic**
DICTATED		Mexico Taiwan	Brazil Chile (Spain) Turkey		Bulgaria Hungary		
NEGOTIATED	South Africa		South Korea Uruguay		Mongolia Poland		
ABDICATED		Tunisia	Argentina Greece Portugal			Czechoslovakia East Germany	Philippines (under Marcos) Romania (under Ceaușescu)
IMPOSED BY OUTSIDE POWERS		Grenada	Japan Panama			Nazi Germany	Iraq

NOTE: European traditional authoritarian regimes tended to become competitive oligarchies.

SOURCE: Adapted from information in Table 3.1 of Samuel P. Huntington, *The Third Wave: Democratization in the Late Twentieth Century* (Norman, OK: University of Oklahoma Press, 1991), 113.

DEMOCRATIZATION

Not all successful transitions lead to successful consolidation. The process can break down for a number of reasons. The textbook identifies three main challenges:

(1) Make democracy "deeper" (i.e., "more comprehensive, accountable and fair;" going from an "electoral" to a "full" democracy), so that the public strongly supports democracy and the leaders of major political forces reliably act within the framework of democracy. Also requires a "thick" version of the "rule of law" (which meaningfully constrains the exercise of power).

(2) Achieve "successful regime performance in terms of public policy outcomes;" this expands legitimacy, and legitimacy in turn makes successful performance more likely because elites are more likely to cooperate and the public is more likely to comply.

(3) "Institutionalization:" institutions/organizations acquire "value and stability" (become more resilient, efficient, predictable, adaptable).

DEMOCRATIZATION

As noted, we focus on three general questions:

1. What explains the spread of democracy over the last 200 years?
2. Why does democracy survive and remains stable in some places, but collapses in others?
3. Why did the process of democratization start in the West? And why are the world's most successful democracies concentrated in the Western world?

Each of these questions defies a simple explanation; what we can do here and now is simply make some general considerations that suggest what an answer might look like.

Also, keep in mind that different factors (or different combinations of factors) may be more/less important depending on the country.

1. DEMOCRACY'S SPREAD

1. What explains the spread of democracy over the last 200 years?

The question can be "unpacked" into two components:

* The fact that democracy spread so widely throughout the world as a system of government, and even more widely as an aspiration and an ideal, calls for explaining why democracy appeals to large constituencies of people—indeed, why it appeals strongly enough for members of these constituencies to fight and die for it.
* The fact that democracy spread over the last 200 years calls for explaining why its appeal has become esp. strong during this time; or, why groups desiring democracy have managed to fight more effectively during this time.

We examine these two issues in turn.

1. DEMOCRACY'S SPREAD

a. Democracy appeals to excluded or subordinate populations:

* As a means to an end (economic or policy): Groups denied participation in government under non-democratic rule see democratic rights as a way to protect their economic interests. Civil rights protect citizens from arbitrary government action, allowing them to pursue their interests on an equal footing, irrespective of birth and social status. Through their political rights, the majority of the electorate can push through policies that redistribute wealth, provide freedom from exploitation, expand access to government services, and guarantee a minimal standard of living.
* As an end in and of itself: Because a regime based on individual equality satisfies the people's desire for "recognition"—the desire to live in a society that recognizes their equal worth, status, and dignity as human beings.

1. DEMOCRACY'S SPREAD

b. Why did democracy spread in the past 200 years?

It is not a coincidence that the spread of democracy has taken place just as the spread of "free" market capitalism and then the "Industrial Revolution" resulted in unprecedented rates of economic expansion and technological innovation.

These developments caused social transformations that favored the spread of democracy:

* Transformation of peasants into industrial workers who were less steeped in traditional (conservative) values, easier to mobilize in defense of their interests, and more interested (and more effective) in organizing for higher wages, better working conditions, government assistance/services, economic redistribution, and voting rights;

1. DEMOCRACY'S SPREAD

b. These developments caused social transformations that favored the spread of democracy (continued):

* Rise of a commercial/industrial bourgeoisie, which demanded political power to match their economic strength;
* Emergence of an educated, urban middle class demanding individual rights, legal protection for private property, opportunities for upward mobility, and meritocratic government reforms.

By and large, the outcomes we observe in different countries vary depending on the size and strength of each of these groups, how such groups were organized/mobilized into political parties and social movements, as well as the patterns of alliances, rivalries, and the interactions between these groups.

2. (UN)STABLE DEMOCRACY

2. Why does democracy remain stable in some places, but collapses in others?

Perhaps the key point to emphasize here is the vulnerability of democracy in the presence of low levels of economic development.

Low development makes democracy vulnerable to:

* Economic crises, which threaten to impress on even the poorest members of society that democracy cannot meet their basic interests and aspirations;
* Wealthy elites (including commercial/industrial capitalists, who had previously demanded that the system open up), who fear the redistributive tendencies of democracy; the threat is esp. marked at low levels of development, making elites more willing to try to overthrow democracy;

2. (UN)STABLE DEMOCRACY

2. Why does democracy survive and remains stable in some places, but collapses in others? Low development makes democracy vulnerable to (continued):

* The middle class: In places where the urban middle class is a minority of the electorate, its support of democracy tends to be more tenuous, making this group available to co-optation by elites in “anti-democratic” projects.

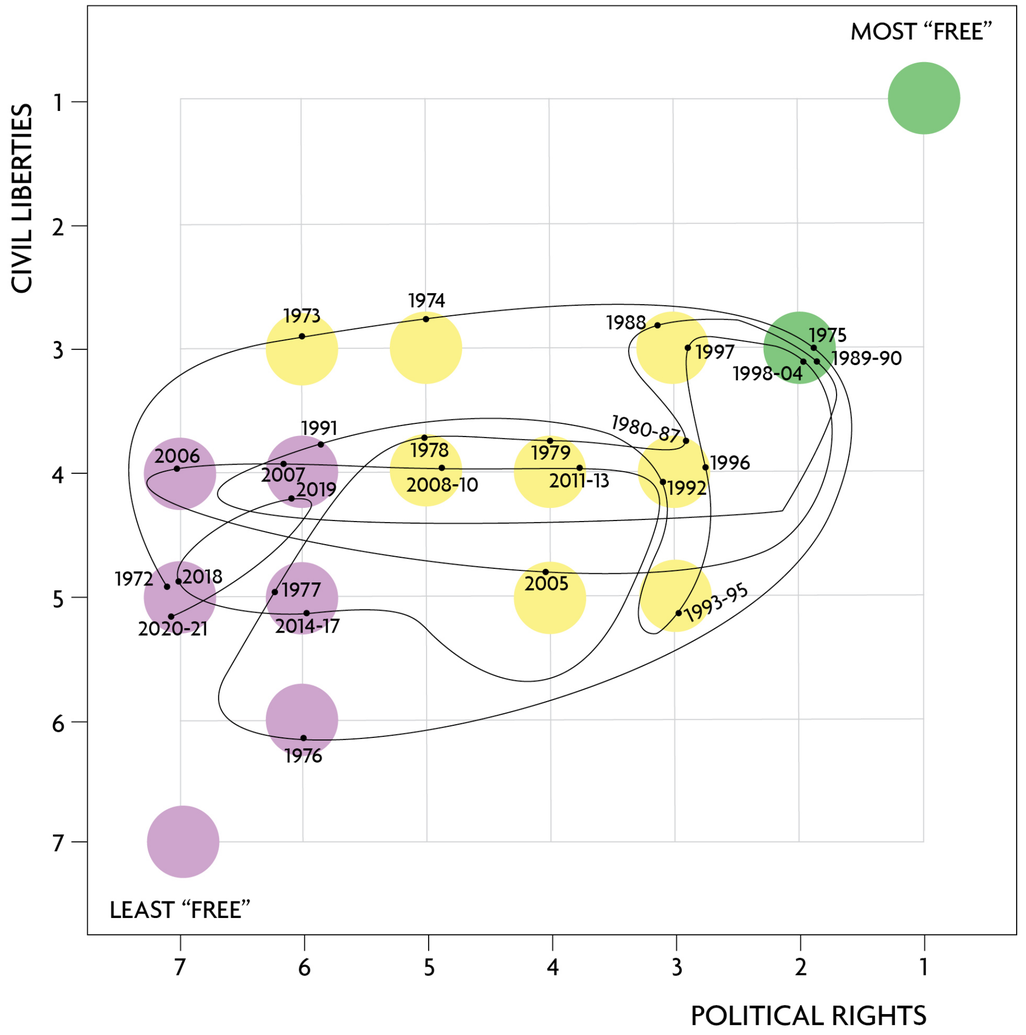
Conversely, democracy has been found to be almost “impregnable” beyond certain (high) levels of income.

This means that if a democratic regime manages to stay in place during a country’s transition to “developed” status, or if democracy is established in the presence of high levels of development, the chances that it will collapse are virtually nil.

Table 9.5 **Highly Oscillating States since 1974**

	Regime in 1973	Regime as of the end of 2021	Frequencies since 1974		
			Democratic Transitions	Democratic Breakdowns	Total Regime Changes
Macedonia	Autocracy	Democracy	4	3	7
Albania	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Bangladesh	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Georgia	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Niger	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Sri Lanka	Democracy	Democracy	3	3	6
Thailand	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Turkey	Autocracy	Autocracy	3	3	6
Guinea-Bissau	Autocracy	Democracy	3	2	5
Nigeria	Autocracy	Democracy	3	2	5
Pakistan	Democracy	Autocracy	2	3	5
Suriname	Autocracy	Democracy	3	2	5
Ukraine	Autocracy	Democracy	3	2	5
Zambia	Autocracy	Democracy	3	2	5
Haiti	Autocracy	Autocracy	2	2	4
Jamaica	Democracy	Democracy	2	2	4
Mali	Autocracy	Autocracy	2	2	4
Papua New Guinea	Autocracy	Autocracy	2	2	4
Philippines	Autocracy	Autocracy	2	2	4
Senegal	Autocracy	Autocracy	2	2	4

THAILAND'S FREEDOM HOUSE RATINGS, 1972-2022



Freedom House scores range from 1 (best) to 7 (worst). Because Freedom House publishes its scores in January of each year, its assessment refers to the previous year (e.g., scores issued in 2014 refer to 2013). For the purposes of this graph, each data point describes Thailand's performance during the year the Freedom House scores cover, not the year in which the scores were published. Colour shadings reflect overall ratings of 'Free' (green), 'Partly Free' (yellow), and 'Not Free' (purple).

3. ‘WESTERN’ DEMOCRACY?

3. Why did the process of democratization start in the Western world? And why are the most successful democracies concentrated in the Western world?

“Cultural” explanations to these questions (which try to identify what aspects of “Western” culture make Western nations more hospitable to democracy) remain very popular.

There are “Western” versions (e.g., Samuel Huntington’s 1996 book *The Clash of Civilisations*) and “Eastern”/“Asian” versions (e.g., Lee Kwan Yew’s “Asian Values” thesis) of this narrative, depending on the value judgments made regarding the supposedly “Asian” style of governance.

The reason why not much is made anymore of “Asian values” is that the idea has been exposed as deeply flawed (and kind of racist, too!).

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

In a famous 1993 article written in the newspaper *International Herald Tribune* (titled "The 10 Values That Undergird East Asian Strength and Success") Singaporean intellectual/diplomat Tommy Koh described 10 values "East Asians" (all?) ostensibly share. He put it this way (these are direct quotes):

(1) East Asians do not believe in the extreme form of individualism practiced in the West. We agree that every individual is important. However, he or she is not an isolated being, but a member of a nuclear and extended family, clan, neighborhood, community, nation and state. East Asians believe that whatever they do or say, they must keep in mind the interests of others. Unlike Western society, where an individual puts his interests above all others, in Asian society the individual tries to balance his interests with those of family and society.

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

(2) East Asians believe in strong families. Divorce rates are much lower than those in the West, and Asians do not, as a rule, abandon their aged parents. They believe that the family is the building block of society.

(3) East Asians revere education. Unlike the West, this is a value held not only by the elite but by all strata of society. Asian mothers would make any sacrifice to help their children excel in school. [...] Asian students consistently outperform their Western counterparts in mathematics and science. This will give Asia a competitive edge [...]

(4) East Asians believe in the virtues of saving and frugality. It is no accident that Singapore's saving rate is the highest in the world [...] East Asians believe, as individuals, families and governments, that they should lead frugal lives and live within their means. This is better than the Western addiction to consumption, paying "on time" and living under a mountain of debt.

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

(5) East Asians consider hard work a virtue—the chief reason this region is outcompeting Europe.

(6) East Asians practice national teamwork. Unions and employers view each other as partners, not class enemies. Together, government, business and employees work cooperatively for the good of the nation. This philosophy, combined with the ability to forge national consensus, is one of the secrets of the so-called East Asian development miracle.

(7) There is an Asian version of a social contract between the people and the state. The government will maintain law and order, provide citizens with their basic needs for jobs, housing, education and health care. Governments also have an obligation to treat their people with fairness and humanity.

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

In return, citizens are expected to be law-abiding, respect those in authority, work hard, save, and motivate their children to learn and be self-reliant. Most Asian governments do not pay unemployment benefits, partly because there is little unemployment and partly to avoid the Western disease of welfarism. Asian governments do not make welfare payments to unmarried women with dependent children because teenage pregnancy and illegitimate birth are, fortunately, rare in Asia.

(8) In some Asian countries, governments have sought to make every citizen a stakeholder in the country. More than 90 percent of Singaporeans own their own homes. Singapore also has the world's highest percentage of citizens who own shares (50.5 percent, compared to 16.2 percent in Britain, and 11.7 percent in the United States). Each year, employees in the private and public sectors [...]

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

[...] receive a performance-based bonus. This year, for example, every public-sector employee in Singapore will receive three and a half months' salary as bonus. Some employees in the private sector will receive even more. In these ways, we try to build communitarian societies.

(9) East Asians want their governments to maintain a morally wholesome environment in which to bring up their children. A recent survey found that most Singaporeans do not want magazines such as Playboy to circulate in the country. Recently, the democratically elected government in Seoul refused to allow Michael Jackson to perform in South Korea. There is no reason Asians must adopt the Western view that pornography, obscenity, lewd language and behavior, and attacks on religion are protected by the right of free speech.

THE ASIAN VALUES THESIS

(10) Good governments in East Asia want a free press but, unlike the West, they do not believe that such freedom is an absolute right. We do not want our press to be mere mouthpieces of government. Yet we believe that the press must act responsibly. For example, it has no right to instigate trouble between racial, religious or linguistic groups, or between countries. We also insist that the press should give those whom it has attacked the right to reply.

Taken together, these 10 values form a framework that has enabled societies in East Asia to achieve economic prosperity, progress, harmonious relations between citizens, and law and order (Singapore and Tokyo are the two safest cities in the world).

3. ‘WESTERN’ DEMOCRACY?

Specifically, what evidence is there that values inconsistent with democracy (such as collectivism, respect of social hierarchy, subservience to authority, intolerance of diversity of identity and opinion) are both *widely held* across “Asia” as well as *unique* to Asia?

Also, it is apparent that views on culture and democracy in Asia are hard to separate from competing interests in struggles for power—those in power (and those who benefit from their association with the regime) have one view, while those without any power typically have another.

It is also no coincidence that when people in Asia take to the streets, it’s generally to demand democracy, not dictatorship (with some exceptions, like Thailand).

Are they wrong? Or maybe they were duped by the “West?” That seems to be what the proponents of “Asian Values” want you to believe.

3. ‘WESTERN’ DEMOCRACY?

It should also be mentioned that “the West” itself is no stranger to authoritarian, communitarian, or hierarchical ideas; democracy is a very recent achievement. Most “Western” nations have been “democratic” or have held “democratic values” for a tiny fraction of their history (in most instances, less than a century).

It is true that Greek city-states pioneered a form of direct democracy 2500 years ago, but until recently democracy had never been seen as a model applicable beyond the local level. At the local level, moreover, many places in Asia have long traditions of elected leaders and public deliberations.

In fact, just as there is much evidence for “authoritarian” elements in “Western” culture, there is much evidence of texts and practices of “Eastern” cultures that value individual freedom, equality, tolerance of other people’s views, and public debate.

3. ‘WESTERN’ DEMOCRACY?

Given the amount of money and resources authoritarian regimes spend on propagating their own interpretations of “culture,” making sure that the populations they rule act accordingly, maintaining surveillance mechanisms monitoring deviations from orthodoxy, censoring alternative viewpoints, and slandering/imprisoning/killing those who think differently, the idea that these regimes are simply a reflection of cultural values is pretty absurd.

“Culture” is no obstacle to democracy; in both the West and the East, the adoption of democracy marks continuity with some old cultural values and a break with others. The desire to be free and to be recognized as equal to anyone else is neither Western nor Eastern—it is a human aspiration, for which people in many parts of the world have fought and died over hundreds of years.

So why are the world’s successful democracies concentrated in the Western world?

3. ‘WESTERN’ DEMOCRACY?

A more satisfying explanation combines some of the insights above: Democratization started in the West because the West experienced social transformations favoring democratization the earliest; stable democracies are more common in the West today because the West is by and large highly developed.

The non-Western world, conversely, is less “democratic” because lower levels of development have made democracy more unstable and prone to collapse.

Much of the non-Western world is still undergoing the social transformations Europe went through a century ago; in some places, the transformations have taken place in the presence of strong authoritarian regimes that have proven more effective in suppressing or adapting to democratic challenges than the old aristocratic regimes of Western Europe (greater coercive powers, greater mismatch between the strength of the state and civil society).

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